

NATION IN DENIAL

JAIPUR BRINGS OUT THE SOFT CORE OF A STOIC INDIA THAT HAS BECOME ONE OF THE LONGEST SUFFERING VICTIMS OF RADICAL ISLAMISM

■ By S. Prasannarajan

The customary day-after outrage will pass. So will the tedium of whodunit. In no time Jaipur will be just another entry in the glossary of terror. We will soon regain the cosy smugness of normalcy... tomorrow is another day, another city, and more body parts and other horrors on the television screen. At the moment, we are condemned to suffer the platitudinous bunkum of the ruling class with no political will to contain the nihilistic fury of radical Islamism. The blood on the picture postcard city is one more reminder we didn't need: India is under attack, and every pause has been a deception. The enemy is not some distant abstraction but a fattened beneficiary of our liberal democracy; an enemy whose allegiance is not to his nationality but to an angry god. For the jihadi, India has become the easiest, and the least resistant, route to paradise. Jaipur magnifies the soft core of a stoic state, where fatalism has become the abiding political trait.

Why is it that India refuses to accept its status as one of the most vulnerable victim states of Islamist terror, in spite of Delhi 2005, Mumbai 2006, and Hyderabad 2007, not to speak of the attack on Parliament three months after 9/11? The answer stretches back to the pre-Tora Bora era of jihad, when Kashmir was the site of the banality of terror, but with limited sub-continental relevance. It took the burning towers of the World Trade Center for America to confront the new Evil after the fall of communism. The "evil" might have been familiar to us, but in less dramatic contexts of course. Still, it is a truism to say that 9/11 has changed the world—and made fear a geopolitical entity, something India or Israel couldn't achieve despite their longer but less spectacular experience with radical Islamism. We were all Americans that day, as *Le Monde* fa-

mously said, but we didn't all change like the Americans. Patriotism didn't have a party tag when America erupted in rage and sorrow, and the victim identified the enemy and declared the first war—a just war—of the 21st century. The much-caricatured George Bush can't be denied his place in history as a moral warrior, no matter how his morality went wrong in the post-Saddam Mesopotamia.

We are neither Americans nor Israelis in our response to the genocidal profanities of faith. We are not a nation on permanent vigil, and patriotism, in certain quarters of left-liberal India, is a vulgarity, as nationalism is a dirty word. We may not have to go to the extent of Guantanamo and other extremities but, in the age of the jihadist martyrdom chic, giving up a little bit of civil liberty for the common good is not the same as giving in to the paranoia of a totalitarian state. The Government killed POTA because it was "draconian", but what has it got as an alternative? It is as if this Government's humanism abhors any law that violates the fundamental rights of the terrorist. States like Gujarat and Rajasthan have passed anti-terror bills but they haven't yet got the Presidential assent, though such laws exist in Congress-ruled Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh. Can the UPA regime dismiss Narendra Modi's demand for a chief ministers' conference on national security in the wake of Jaipur as the ranting of the "*maut ka saudagar*"? We can see who is playing politics here.

That is the politics of minorityism. Its finest practitioners can't afford to repudiate the ghettos that are votebanks, even if it means national security is the loser in the bargain. Afzal Guru, a terrorist sentenced to death, is allowed to languish as a rallying point, as a 'symbolic cause' for the street fighters for whom India is a wretched place

It is as if this government's humanism abhors any law that violates the fundamental rights of the terrorist. Politics of minorityism is at play.